

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Flatulence poses no danger to your health or to that of your unborn baby, but it can be embarrassing and cause cramping. If you have cramping that doesn't feel like gas, contact your doctor.

» What can I do?

Try to avoid eating too many foods that are high in saturated fats and carbohydrates that are known for causing gas (brussels sprouts, prunes, cauliflower, asparagus, cabbage, artichokes, beans, and so on). A balanced diet should keep flatulence to a minimum. Eating little and often will help your gut keep up. Make sure you sit upright when you eat and slowly chew every mouthful of food.

Vaginal discharge

» What, when, and how often?

Known medically as leucorrhea, vaginal discharge is part of your body's natural cleansing system—and it's perfectly normal to have more of it during pregnancy.

» What causes it?

During pregnancy the layer of muscle in the vagina thickens and cells lining the vagina increase in response to rises in the pregnancy hormone estrogen. This helps the vagina to prepare for childbirth. The increase in cells mean a rise in volume of vaginal discharge.

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Healthy vaginal discharge is not an indicator of anything being wrong with your pregnancy. It's completely normal.

» What can I do?

If the discharge is so heavy that it could leak onto clothing, use sanitary pads to soak up excess. Consult your doctor if the discharge is foul smelling or tinged with blood. He or she will need to take a swab to see if you have an infection. Consult him or her if the discharge is persistent, which could indicate premature rupture of the membranes. Avoid the temptation to "wash it away" since you could upset your body's natural cleansing and antibacterial balance, and cause yeast.

Yeast

» What, when, and how often?

Yeast—or vaginal candidiasis to give it its medical name—is a fungal infection that causes a proliferation of candida albicans (a natural yeast) in the vaginal tract. It causes increased vaginal discharge (which can smell of yeast), sometimes pain during sexual intercourse, and some soreness and itchiness in the vagina.

» What causes it?

An increase in pregnancy hormones causes the body's natural sugars to increase around the vagina, which "feeds" candida. Sometimes the infection is sexually

transmitted, but yeast often occurs while taking, or just after, a course of antibiotics.

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During pregnancy, yeast poses no risks to your baby, but the infection can pass to the baby during vaginal birth.

» What can I do?

Avoid using perfumed soaps and bubble baths, which can hamper the work of natural flora in your vagina at fighting the candida infection. See your doctor, who will confirm the infection using a vaginal swab and may then prescribe a topical cream or a suppository to kill the candida (don't use over-the-counter medicines and do not take oral medication for yeast). Usually one prescribed suppository will clear the problem. If you are at the beginning of your pregnancy, you'll probably have to wait until you are in your second trimester to have any treatment at all. Your partner will need to be treated too, since yeast can be passed back and forth between you.

80% of women will experience nausea or vomiting in early pregnancy.

Constipation

» What, when, and how often?

Feeling that you need a bowel movement and either being unable to do so, or finding doing so painful or uncomfortable means that you are constipated. Stools, when they do pass, tend to be hard and dry, and may tear the delicate mucous lining of your bowel as they make their way out. This can cause some bleeding. Constipation can occur at any time during pregnancy, but is common in the first trimester.

» What causes it?

During pregnancy your intestines and bowel have slowed down because of the increase in progesterone in your system. This means that your stool spends longer in your colon, and water gets reabsorbed from it into your body, thus making the stool hard. The effects are compounded later in pregnancy because your bowel, like everything else in your abdomen, is squashed and has less room to do its job. Iron supplements (if you're taking them) can exacerbate constipation, so talk to your doctor about whether it's safe for you to stop.

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Constipation is uncomfortable for you and can cause embarrassing gas, but it doesn't pose any harm to your unborn baby.

» What can I do?

Keep yourself hydrated—drink at least eight glasses of



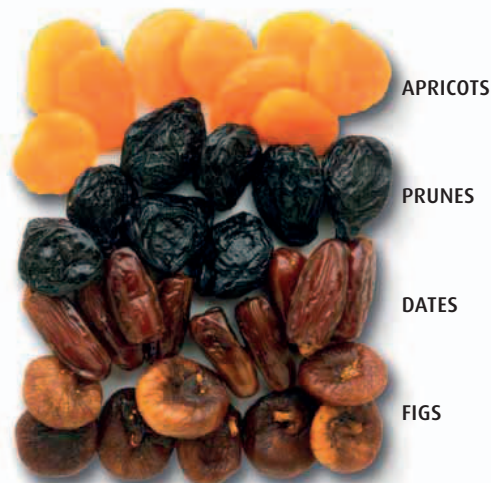
Did you know...

An alternative way to relieve the symptoms of yeast is to smear the area with live yogurt or wear a sanitary pad with live yogurt on the surface (for a short period of time). You can also try a warm bath with a few drops of vinegar added to the water. You should always wear cotton underwear since it allows your vagina to breathe. Do not wear tight jeans or pants that decrease the flow of air to this area and rub against it (if you already have yeast), making you more uncomfortable.



DRINK LOTS OF WATER

water a day, as this will help to keep your stool soft. Make sure your diet contains plenty of fiber (see p.50), including dried fruit such as dried apricots and prunes, which can have a laxative effect on your bowel. Eat little and often so that your bowel doesn't have too much to deal with at any one time. Keep moving: doing regular, gentle exercise appropriate for your pregnancy will also give your bowel a helping hand.



APRICOTS

PRUNES

DATES

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